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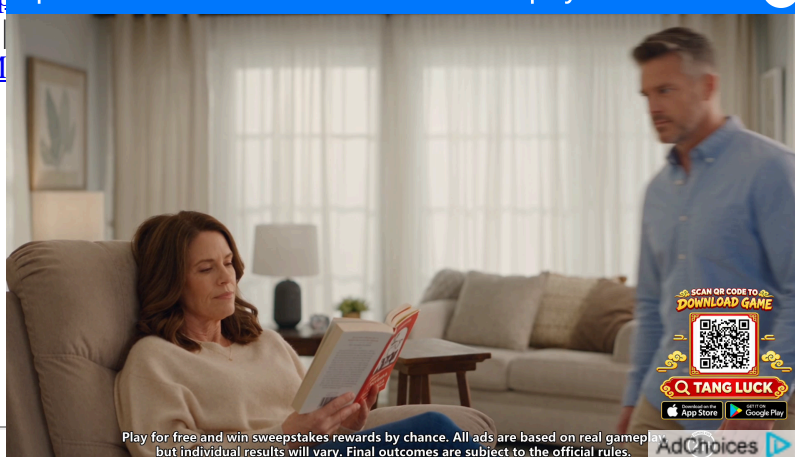
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20262025

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BAL CHW ATH
 BOS CLE HOU
 NYY DET LAA
 TBR KCR SEA
 TOR MIN TEX

NL

ATL CHC ARI
 MIA CIN COL
 NYM MIL LAD
 PHI PIT SDP
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Position Adjustments

by [Dave Cameron](#)

December 17, 2008

Back before the winter meetings started and there were no transactions, we took up all of our writing here, we were all ridiculous statistics section. Now that we have a lull in transactions, metrics, and evaluating the best ways to view them. No issues.

Starting off, I want to talk about positional context. If I asked you who the best defensive player in baseball was, would your answer be [Carl Crawford](#)? Probably not. He's definitely an asset defensively, but does anyone think he's really the best defensive player in the game? His 2008 UZR/150 is better than everyone else, though, so if you were just sorting the entire league by that metric, Crawford stands head and shoulders above everyone else.

However, we all instinctively understand that the quality of defenders at each position is not even. Crawford rates remarkably well as a left fielder in large part due to the fact that left fielders are lousy defenders as a group. In fact, if we just look at UZR/150 for qualified left fielders in 2008, only three of the 13 players on the list have above average rankings – Crawford at 28.6, Fred Lewis at 12.1, and [Matt Holliday](#) at 5.2. The bottom of the list is populated by guys who should be DH'ing – [Pat Burrell](#), [Raul Ibanez](#), and [Adam Dunn](#). Teams use left field as a hiding ground for good hitters with lousy defensive abilities in order to get their bats in the line-up, so when a team like Tampa goes the alternate direction and sticks a good glove in LF, he's going to look like a superstar, thanks to the relative uselessness of his peers.

If Crawford played CF, which is his more natural position given his defensive abilities, he'd certainly rate a lot lower than +28 runs. This isn't because CF is any harder to play than LF, but simply because the people he would be compared to are much better defensively than the LFers. It's somewhat obvious, but I've seen a lot of people talk about CF being lower because of the harder nature of the position. That's a comparison.

If [Carl Crawford](#) was put into a room of 5'5 people, he'd appear short. Think of left field, right field, first base, etc. The best defensive player in the league being held to is so low.

This is why, when you see us talking about total value in our discussion. Since each player is being rated by UZR on a scale that neutralizes all of the averages so that they're

Tom Tango has developed the most commonly accepted set of positional adjustments out there right now, based on historical data of how players perform when they move from one position to another. [His scale](#) is as follows:

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Catcher: +12.5 runs
Shortstop: +7.5 runs
Second Base: +2.5 runs
Third Base: +2.5 runs
Center Field: +2.5 runs
Left Field: -7.5 runs
Right Field: -7.5 runs
First Base: -12.5 runs
Designated Hitter: -17.5 runs

Essentially, the width of the spectrum of major league players being used at their best positions is about 30 runs – if you have a league average defensive catcher and you make him a full time DH, you’ve whacked about three wins off of his value.

These positional adjustments match up with common knowledge pretty well – catchers are scarce, shortstops are the best non-catcher defenders, and the immobile stiffes get hidden at DH/1B/LF/RF, depending on how just how immobile they really are. It’s the middle part of the spectrum – second base, third base, and center field – that cause some disagreement. We’ll get into those three positions specifically this afternoon.

[Non-Tendering Wigginton](#)

[Kyle’s Future in San Diego May Be Blank](#)

Dave is the Managing Editor of FanGraphs.

14 COMMENTS

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d 17 years ago

why wouldn't it be 5 runs from catcher to DH (vs. 3), no

0

Dave Cameron Member since 2018 17 years ago

Catchers are +12.5, DHs are -17.5. The absolute value difference is 30 runs, which is about three wins.

0

Eric Walkingshaw 17 years ago

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One thing I notice (which may or may not have any significance), is that the position adjustments for all positions excluding DH sums to 0. This seems to make sense—the position adjustments are “normalized” in some sense, so that you’re not under- or overvaluing players in general.

Once you include DH, however, that falls apart. Does this mean that after applying positional adjustments, we have a net undervaluing of all players? Should positional adjustments be normalized differently in the AL and NL to prevent this?

Thanks in advance for any responses.

👍 1 🗨

Eric Walkingshaw ⌚ 17 years ago

| 🗨 Reply to [Eric Walkingshaw](#)

One problem with normalizing AL and NL position adjustments differently is that it would become more difficult to compare players across leagues, so that doesn’t seem like a good solution.

Relatedly, if position adjustments were renormalized to prevent undervaluing, we have to keep in mind that there are fewer DHs than players at other positions. So to prevent overvaluing, we wouldn’t want the position adjustments to sum directly to zero, instead, the weighted (by the number of positional slots) position adjustments would sum to zero.

All of this assumes that this is even relevant / a problem.

👍 0 🗨

Dave Cameron **Member since 2018** ⌚ 17 years ago

| 🗨 Reply to [Eric Walkingshaw](#)

Yea, the sum to zero question is an interesting one. I’ll probably do a whole post on it in the next few days.

👍 0 🗨

Sky ⌚ 17 years ago

Dave, I obviously love that you’re talking about this. And

One thing that might deserve clarification — why do teams value DHs so much? Is there some inherent difficulty difference between LF and C? Or, if you don’t like to talk in terms of difficulty, you could argue that DHs have better their skills — more balls are hit their way.

👍 0 🗨

Dave Cameron **Member since 2018** ⌚ 17 years ago

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|  Reply to [Sky](#)

Right, I'd phrase it in the latter way – teams hide players at positions where they'll have the least amount of opportunities to display their awfulness. They play LF instead of CF because LFs get fewer chances to screw up.

I wouldn't say CF is harder to play than LF, only that the extra opportunities magnify defensive abilities, both good and bad. And for lousy defenders, magnification of that lousiness is not what teams are looking for.

 0 

Margery  15 years ago

|  Reply to [Sky](#)

There is a critical shortage of informative articles like this.

 0 

lookatthosetwins  17 years ago

One thing I'd like to know is, how much value does Crawford gain by being in center field? I would guess not as much as most people think. The position adjustment and the increased competition should cancel out so the only thing adding value is the amount of balls he gets. So I guess I'm wondering what the increase would be in balls in his zone, and how much value does that actually increase? How much value does Manny lose if he gets moved to center?

 0 

Sky  17 years ago

|  Reply to [lookatthosetwins](#)

Assuming league-average talent at a position (with all positions being considered) and a league-normal player, moving a player, beyond the learning curve.

But as players get much better than positional-average, moving them to show off more of their skills, because they're better, moving them to "easier" positions is a good move, because their absolute value versus percentage change thing. The further you move them, the more it matters.

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philosofool  17 years ago

Dave,

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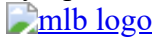
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Mitchel Lichtman

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